

Customer Communication & Escalation Framework

Say the right thing, at the right time, on the right channel.

SOP-CX-003

Version 1.0

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CX & Operations

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1. PURPOSE

This SOP establishes clear standards for how [Company Name] communicates with customers across all channels and defines the escalation framework for ensuring issues are resolved at the right level. Consistent, professional communication builds trust and protects the company's reputation.

2. SCOPE

- All staff who communicate with customers in any capacity
- All customer-facing communication channels phone, email, chat, social media and in-person
- Internal escalation communications between teams and management

3. COMMUNICATION PRINCIPLES

All customer communication at [Company Name] must adhere to the following principles:

Principle	What It Means in Practice
Clear	Use simple, jargon-free language. The customer should always understand what you are saying.
Empathetic	Acknowledge the customer's feelings before providing solutions. Always validate their experience.
Accurate	Never make promises you cannot keep. Only communicate what has been confirmed.
Timely	Respond within defined SLAs. If more time is needed, inform the customer proactively.

Professional	Maintain a respectful and courteous tone at all times, regardless of the customer's behavior.
Consistent	Use approved templates and language. Avoid contradictory messaging across channels.

4. COMMUNICATION CHANNELS & STANDARDS

Each channel has specific use cases, tone guidelines, and response SLAs:

	Channel	Best Used For	Tone	SLA
TEL	Phone	Urgent issues, complaints, account queries requiring real-time resolution	Warm & Direct	Answer in 3 rings
EML	Email	Formal communications, documentation, follow-ups, written confirmations	Professional & Detailed	Reply within 4 hours
CHT	Live Chat	Quick queries, product information, account support during business hours	Friendly & Concise	First reply in 2 min
SOC	Social Media	Public queries, brand reputation management, directing to private channels	Positive & Tactful	Acknowledge in 1 hour
F2F	Walk-in / In Person	Complex issues, sensitive matters, high-value customers	Formal & Attentive	Attended immediately

5. APPROVED COMMUNICATION TEMPLATES

All staff must use approved templates to ensure consistency. Templates may be personalized but the core message must not be altered.

► General Acknowledgement

USE WHEN: Customer contacts us with any query or complaint

*Dear [Customer Name],
Thank you for reaching out to us. We have received your message and a member of our team will be in touch with you within [SLA timeframe]. Your reference number is [REF-XXXXX]. Please keep this for your records and future correspondence.
Kind regards,
[Agent Name] |
[Company Name]
Customer Experience Team*

► Escalation Notification to Customer

USE WHEN: Issue cannot be resolved at first contact and must be escalated

*Dear [Customer Name],
Thank you for your patience. We want to ensure your matter receives the attention it deserves. We are escalating your case [REF-XXXXX] to our [relevant team/senior team] for further review. You can expect an update from us by [date/time]. We sincerely apologize for any inconvenience caused.
Kind regards,
[Agent Name] |
[Company Name]
Customer Experience Team*

► Resolution Confirmation

USE WHEN: Issue has been resolved and customer needs to be informed

*Dear [Customer Name],
We are pleased to inform you that your case [REF-XXXXX] has been resolved. [Brief description of resolution]. We appreciate your patience throughout this process. If you have any further questions or concerns, please do not hesitate to contact us.
Warm regards,
[Agent Name] |
[Company Name]
Customer Experience Team*

► Apology Communication

USE WHEN: Company error or service failure has impacted the customer

*Dear [Customer Name],
We sincerely apologize for the inconvenience you experienced with [brief description of issue]. We take full responsibility and have taken steps to ensure this does not happen again. [Description of resolution or next steps]. As a valued customer, your experience matters greatly to us. Thank you for bringing this to our attention.
Sincerely,
[Agent Name] |*

6. ESCALATION FRAMEWORK

Not all issues can or should be resolved at the first point of contact. Use this framework to determine when and how to escalate:

Level	Trigger	Escalate To	Timeframe
Level 1	Issue cannot be resolved within standard SLA	Senior CX Agent / Team Lead	Within 1 hour of SLA breach
Level 2	Customer is dissatisfied with Level 1 resolution	Operations Lead / Manager	Within 2 hours of Level 1 escalation
Level 3	Legal threat, regulatory complaint, or media risk	Compliance Officer / Legal	Immediately upon identification
Level 4	Systemic issue affecting multiple customers	Department Heads	Within 30 minutes

7. DO'S AND DON'TS

DO	DO NOT
Always greet the customer by name	Use jargon, acronyms, or technical terms the customer won't understand
Acknowledge the customer's frustration before offering a solution	Make promises you are not authorized to make
Use approved templates for all written communication	Argue with or dismiss a customer's concerns
Keep the customer informed at every stage	Leave a customer waiting without an update
Document every interaction in the CRM immediately	Share customer information with unauthorized parties
Escalate when in doubt. It is always better to escalate	Attempt to resolve issues outside your authority level

8. DIFFICULT CUSTOMER HANDLING

- Remain calm and professional at all times regardless of the customer's tone
- Never match a customer's aggression. Lower your tone and speak slowly
- If a customer becomes abusive, politely warn them: 'I want to help you but I need us to communicate respectfully'
- If abuse continues, inform the customer you will end the interaction and escalate to a supervisor
- Document all instances of abusive behavior in the CRM with timestamps
- Never end a call or chat without offering the customer an alternative resolution path

9. SLA SUMMARY

Communication Type	First Response	Resolution	Follow-up
Phone	3 rings	During call	Email summary within 1 hour
Email	4 hours	24 hours	Confirmation email on closure
Live Chat	2 minutes	During session	Email transcript if requested
Social Media	1 hour	Move to private channel	Public acknowledgement post
Walk-in	Immediately	Same day where possible	Written summary if needed

10. DOCUMENT CONTROL

Version	Date	Author	Changes
1.0	May 2026	Milkah Muchunu	Initial version